Understanding graph representation learning in reinforcement learning based logic synthesis

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Abstract

Computer chips ought to be as small as possible for cost efficiency. The problem of minimizing chip size while preserving the chip's functionality has been studied through the prism of and-inverter graphs (AIGs), since any Boolean function can be represented by an AIG. Because the complexity of AIG size minimization is unknown—it is an instance of the Minimum Circuit Size Problem, which lies in NP but is not known to be NP-hard—no procedure returns optimal AIGs at the sizes of interest, and there is therefore no supervision signal in the form of optimal AIGs to imitate. Reinforcement learning, and more generally planning, have been used to optimize AIGs in the absence of such a signal. Contemporarily, graph representation learning has been applied to train machine learning models to perform tasks on graph data. More recently, those two technologies have been combined and reported to outperform state-of-the-art logic synthesis heuristics, but the relative importance of graph representation learning in those methods remains unknown. Is graph representation learning useful when optimizing and-inverter graphs with reinforcement learning?

1 Introduction

A circuit that computes a given Boolean function with fewer logic gates occupies less area and is cheaper to manufacture [31]. Given a Boolean function, logic synthesis methods [] are used to find a small circuit that computes it. Because every Boolean function can be represented with AND and NOT gates only, logic synthesis methods represent circuits with and-inverter graphs (AIGs) which nodes are AND gates and edges can invert incoming bits.

However, finding the smallest AIG encoding a given Boolean function is an open problem. It is an instance of the Minimum Circuit Size Problem, which lies in NP but is not known to be NP-hard [16], and which is related to Graph Isomorphism [2]. In practice, AIGs are reduced by applying sequences of heuristics that rewrite the graph while preserving functional equivalence []. Many such heuristics are implemented in the `ABC` [5] software. Choosing the best heuristics sequence is a search problem.

In the absence of exact solvers, machine learning, such as supervised learning, has been applied to AIG minimization [39]. However it suffered from two major weaknesses: first, the supervision signal to train from could be a suboptimal AIG since no exact solver exists, and second, graph generative models are still quite limited []. Successful machine learning approaches are unsupervised ones that only require a scalar signal, often the size of a given AIG which is cheap to obtain: Bayesian optimization [11], multi-armed bandits [30], reinforcement learning (RL) [15, 51] and Monte Carlo tree search [33]. Contemporarily, graph representation learning has been applied to train models on graph data, and circuits are graphs: task-agnostic encoders built specifically for AIGs are now available [19, 22, 49, 50]. The two lines of work have since been combined. Several of the methods above encode the current AIG with a graph neural network rather than with a fixed set of summary

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statistics [51, 33, 3], and achieve reductions beyond the expert ABC heuristics. The motivation is the same as the one behind the very first deep RL algorithm, which was designed specifically for Backgammon [42]: the state space of AIG minimization is huge and cannot be enumerated, so the value of a state has to be generalized from other states. A learned representation of the circuit should carry structural information that statistics discard, and that is what should allow a deep reinforcement learning algorithm [37] to generalize to unseen circuits: "I have seen a similar graph before, I should probably edit the AIG in a similar way to get good results".

What those RL methods do not report is how much of their performance is attributable to the learned representation design. We are not aware of a study that isolates the contribution of the AIG encoder to RL training. Our work reports such an ablation, in the fixed-horizon setting that Zhu et al. [51] introduced and that later work reuses. We keep that pipeline fixed—the Markov decision process, the policy and value heads, the training algorithm and the hyper-parameter grid—and vary only how the AIG is presented to the policy. We show the following results.

Contributions: First, we show that adding a graph convolutional network to the policy does not improve AIG reduction beyond a multi-layer perceptron that reads graph statistics (number of nodes, of levels, . . .). Second, we derive empirical performance bounds–in terms of AIG value prediction–for message passing networks bounded by the 1-dimensional Weisfeiler-Leman refinement as well as for AIGs specific models. Next, we present existing AIG minimization methods.

2 Related work

2.1 Combinational optimization

Combinational synthesis is a class of fast heuristics that reduce an AIG by rewriting it locally, and that work well in practice [24, 25, 7]. ABC [5] is the reference implementation and is widely used both in industry and academia. Throughout this paper we call *primitives* its standard local transformations, `balance`, `rewrite`, `resub` and `refactor`, and *heuristics* the named sequences of primitives it ships, such as `resyn2`. Since no primitive is globally optimal, reduction is done by composing them into heuristics. Hand-designed heuristics are the reference points against which learned methods are measured: `resyn` [32] applies `balance`, `rewrite`, `balance`, `rewrite`, `balance`. Searching over sequences of primitives has been automated without learned circuit representations, with Bayesian optimization [11] and with multi-armed bandits [30].

2.2 Graph representation learning for AIGs

A separate line of work learns representations of circuits that are meant to transfer across circuits, rather than a policy for one circuit. DeepGate4 [50] is a fundation model that learns node embeddings of AIGs, supposidly useful for various downstream tasks on AIGs. Three encoders from this line—DeepGate [19], PolarGate [22] and FuncGNN [49]—are among the models we evaluate in Section 5.2. `GraphBench` [39] is, to our knowledge, the first AIG reduction benchmark built for methods that must perform on unseen AIGs. It provides a training set of Boolean functions of varying input and output dimension and a disjoint test set, and it reports node reduction relative to the expert ABC heuristic: `resyn2`, `resyn2`, `dc2`, `resyn2rs`, `resyn2`, applied in that order. Its main result is negative: given the AIG obtained by the naive construction from a truth table, specialized DAG generative models [6, 20] do not preserve functional equivalence while reducing size.

2.3 Reinforcement learning for AIGs

The works discussed in this section use similar AIG minimization formulations: the state observed by the trained policy is some represntation of the AIG to minimize and the actions are ABC primitives (sec. 2.1).

Hosny et al. [15] formulate synthesis as an MDP whose states are vectors of AIG statistics—numbers of primary inputs and outputs, nodes, edges, levels and latches, and the proportions of AND and NOT nodes—whose actions are ABC primitives, and whose reward combines node count and level count. Zhu et al. [51] keep ABC primitives as actions but encode the whole AIG with a graph convolutional network, alongside a small vector of statistics and recent actions, and reward the relative reduction in node count. Episodes there have a fixed horizon and no early stopping, so the induced problem is a search over flows of fixed length. This is the formulation we adopt, horizon included, and we state it in full in Section 4. Both Hosny et al. [15] and Zhu et al. [51] train with policy gradient methods [41, 46, 28, 37]. We are not aware of a value-based [45, 27] treatment, even though AIG editing is deterministic. These methods report minimization performances beyond the `ABC` heuristics, but they are not designed to generalize: a policy is trained to reduce one AIG, so the training cost is paid again for every new circuit. Search-based methods lift that restriction. AlphaSyn [33] and AlphaChip [23] plan online and therefore apply to any circuits: every AIG edit choice requires a lookahead, and every lookahead step requires network forward passes. However we argue that the cost of retraining a model is cheap compared to the cost of producing unnecessarily big chips at scale. ABC-RL [3] sits in between: a policy pre-trained on other circuits guides the tree search, and its influence is scaled down when the circuit at hand is far from anything in the training set. Two further formulations widen the setting rather than the state: ESE [35] adds technology mapping operations to the action space and trains with PPO [37], and CB-EVO [21] drops the sequential state altogether and treats the choice of primitive as a contextual bandit whose context is a set of circuit features.

2.4 Graph reinforcement learning for other combinatorial optimization

AIG reduction is an instance of graph structure optimization in the taxonomy of Darvariu et al. [8], who survey reinforcement learning applied to combinatorial problems on graphs and report that a graph neural network encoder is the common choice of state representation. Within chip design the same combination is used for transistor sizing [44] and for macro placement [23]; in both cases the encoder is motivated as the component that enables transfer to new circuits. Next, we formulate AIG minimization as a Markov decision problem.

3 Background material

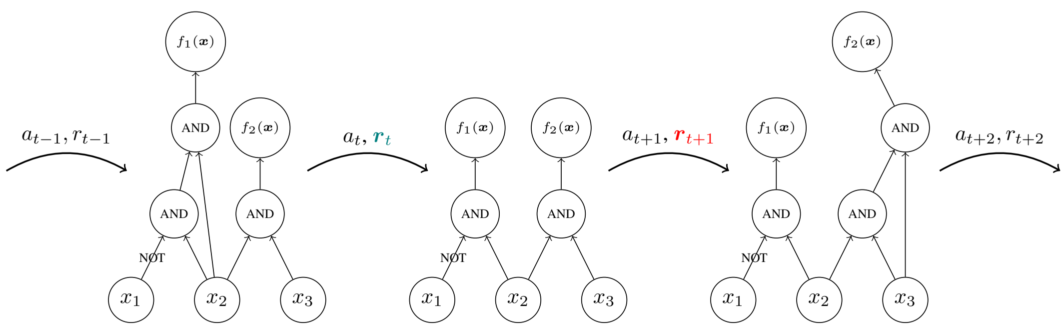

Figure 1: A trajectory in a generic MDP for AIG reduction, on AIGs of the Boolean function $f(x_1, x_2, x_3) = (\bar{x_1} \wedge x_2,\ x_2 \wedge x_3)$. Every method surveyed in Section 2 acts at this granularity: each action is one `ABC` primitive applied to the whole graph, and the primitives of Section 2.1 preserve functional equivalence by construction, so every state reachable from $\mathcal{G}_0$ still computes f.

3.1 And-inverter graphs minimization

Given an arbitrary Boolean function $f : \{0,1\}^n \to \{0,1\}^m$, the objective is to find an and-inverter graph that encodes f with as few nodes as possible.

Section 3.2.1 from Stoll et al. [39] states that an and-inverter graph $\mathcal{G} := (V, E)$ is a directed acyclic graph of in-degree (fanin) at most two. The node set is partitioned into input nodes of in-degree 0, $V^{in} := \{v_1^{in}, \dots, v_n^{in}\}$, AND nodes of in-degree two, $V^{AND} := \{v_1^{AND}, \dots, v_k^{AND}\}$, and output nodes of in-degree one, $V^{out} := \{v_1^{out}, \dots, v_m^{out}\}$; AIGs are therefore heterogeneous graphs [38]. The edge set is $E \subseteq V \times V \times \{0,1\}$, with 0 indicating direct transmission and 1 indicating input negation (NOT). For an input $\boldsymbol{x} \in \{0,1\}^n$, values are assigned to input nodes, propagated through gate nodes (applying inversion where specified), and collected at output nodes to yield $\mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{x}) \in \{0,1\}^m$. Because the combination of AND and NOT is functionally complete, any Boolean function can be represented using only these two operations.

We write $\mathcal{G}_f := \{\mathcal{G} : \mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{x}) = f(\boldsymbol{x})\ \forall \boldsymbol{x} \in \{0,1\}^n\}$ for the set of AIGs functionally equivalent to f. AIGs are non-canonical representations of Boolean functions [26]—two different AIGs can represent the same function—so $|\mathcal{G}_f| > 1$ in general: e.g. the graphs of Figure 1 are functionally equivalent. Given a Boolean function $f : \{0,1\}^n \to \{0,1\}^m$, we want to find $\mathcal{G}^\star \subseteq \arg\min_{\mathcal{G} \in \mathcal{G}_f} |V|$, the AIGs functionally equivalent to f with as few nodes as possible. The hardness of this problem is not known: it is an instance of the Minimum Circuit Size Problem [16], a well-studied problem in NP that is not known to be NP-hard[1].

3.2 Markov decision process

AIG minimization can be formulated as a sequential decision making task in which the environment is the current AIG, the actions are edits of that AIG, and the rewards are shaped to favor edits that remove nodes. Formally, this is the problem of finding an optimal policy for a Markov decision process (MDP) [4, 34]. An MDP is a tuple $\mathcal{M} = \langle S, A, R, T, T_0 \rangle$. S is a finite set of states representing all possible configurations of the environment (e.g. AIGs, or AIG statistics). A is a finite set of actions available to the agent (e.g. AIG edits). $R : S \times A \to \mathbb{R}$ is a deterministic reward function that assigns a real-valued reward to each state-action pair (e.g. number of deleted nodes). $T : S \times A \to \Delta(S)$ is the transition function that maps state-action pairs to probability distributions over next states $\Delta(S)$ (e.g. how graph edits change the AIG; here the transitions are deterministic). $T_0 \in \Delta(S)$ is the initial distribution over states (e.g. a set of AIGs to reduce).

Given an MDP $\mathcal{M} \equiv \langle S, A, R, T, T_0 \rangle$, the goal of reinforcement learning is to find a policy $\pi : S \to A$ that maximizes the expected discounted sum of rewards $J(\pi) = \mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{t=0}^{\infty} \gamma^t R(s_t, \pi(s_t)) \mid s_0 \sim T_0, s_{t+1} \sim T(s_t, \pi(s_t))\right]$ where $0 < \gamma \leq 1$ is the discount factor that controls the trade-off between immediate and future rewards.

We write $V^\star(s) = \mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{t=0}^{\infty} \gamma^t R(s_t, \pi(s_t)) \mid s_0 \sim= s, s_{t+1} \sim T(s_t, \pi(s_t))\right]$ for the value of a state under an optimal policy, i.e. the discounted sum of rewards collected from s by acting optimally. $V^\star$ is the quantity a critic is trained to approximate in actor-critic methods, and the quantity a state representation must be able to distinguish states by; Section 5.2 uses it to measure what a representation can express, independently of any training procedure.

3.3 Message passing neural networks

A message passing neural network (MPNN) [10] attaches a vector $h_v^{(0)}$ to each node v, initialized from that node's features, and refines it over k rounds: $h_v^{(t+1)} = \phi^{(t)}\Big(h_v^{(t)}, \bigoplus_{u \in \mathcal{N}(v)} \psi^{(t)}\big(h_v^{(t)}, h_u^{(t)}, e_{uv}\big)\Big)$, where $\mathcal{N}(v)$ are the neighbours of v, e_{uv} is an optional label on the edge between u and v, $\bigoplus$ is a permutation-invariant aggregator, and $\phi^{(t)}, \psi^{(t)}$ are learned. A graph-level vector is then obtained by pooling $\{h_v^{(k)}\}_{v \in V}$ with a second permutation-invariant readout. Architectures in this family differ only in the choice of ψ, $\bigoplus$ and ϕ: GCN [18], GIN [47], GAT [43] and GraphSAGE [14] are instances, and so are the AIG-specific encoders we evaluate in Section 5.2.3. They also share a limitation. After k rounds, two nodes that k iterations of the 1-dimensional Weisfeiler-Leman refinement assign the same color carry the same embedding [47, 29, 1], so no network in the family can tell apart two AIGs that 1-WL cannot. Section 5.2.2 turns this into a lower bound on the error of every such encoder.

Next, we present our methodology for studying the effect of MPNNs when using RL to train policies for AIG minimization formulated as an MDP.

4 Methodology

We use the same methdology as Zhu et al. [51] who first combined graph convolutional networks and (deep) reinforcement learning for AIG minimization. We use a similar MDP to their's: the actions are the five `ABC` primitives $\{$`balance`, `rewrite`, `rewrite -z`, `refactor`, `refactor -z`$\}$, transitions are deterministic and every primitive preserves functional equivalence, so every reachable state stays in $\mathcal{G}_f$, and an episode applies exactly $H = 20$ of them to the AIG $\mathcal{G}_0$ to reduce, which makes the induced optimization a search over flows of length 20 from a five-letter alphabet. The reward differs

[1] `https://mcsp.work/index.html`

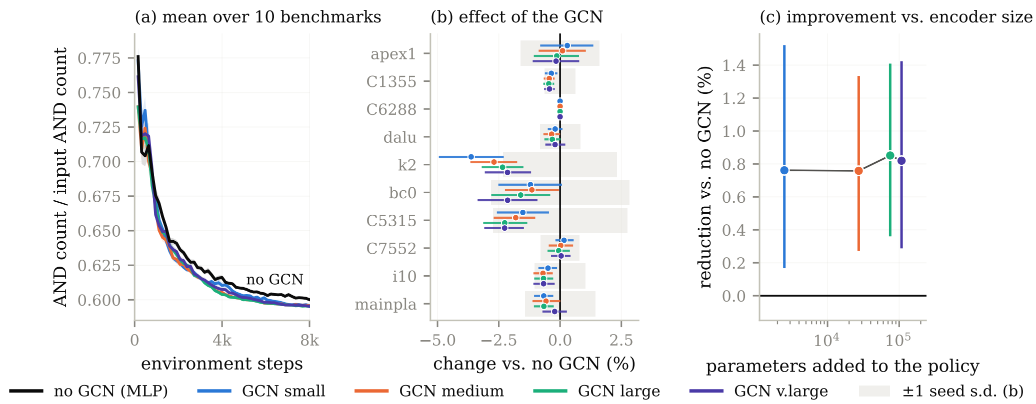

Figure 2: PPO on the ten MLCAD benchmarks with five observation encoders, hyper-parameter matched. (a) mean AND count over the ten benchmarks; (b) per-benchmark change against the MLP, shaded band is one seed standard deviation; (c) mean reduction against the parameters the encoder adds to the policy.

slightly: writing n_t for the number of AND nodes after t actions, $R(s_t, a_t) = 1 - n_{t+1}/n_0$ is issued at every step, so with $\gamma = 1$ we optimize node count alone—the objective of Section 3.1—and not the multi-objective reward of Hosny et al. [15]. Unlike Zhu et al. [51], we use PPO [37] to train policies instead of REINFORCE [46] since the former is the better more modern learner.

The policies we train always read a features vector $x_{\mathcal{G}} \in \mathbb{R}^{|A|+5}$ holding the histogram of the actions taken so far, the AND and level counts of the current and previous AIG relative to $\mathcal{G}_0$, and the normalized time step: this is the same as in Hosny et al. [15], Zhu et al. [51]. This features vector carries no AIG structural information, since two AIGs with the same size, depth and history are indistinguishable to it. The key novelty of Zhu et al. [51] is to feed the policy a graph convolutional network [18] reading the AIG and pooling it into a graph-level vector concatenated with the features vector $x_{\mathcal{G}}$. This GCN addition has since then been built upon [] but never ablated against e.g. Hosny et al. [15]. Ablating GCN, which is the focus of the following sections, is important because while they might increase performances, they definitely add memory and time overheads.

5 Experiments

5.1 Graph reinforcement learning (Zhu et al. [51])

Setup. We use the same AIGs to minimize as Zhu et al. [51]: `apex1`, `bc0`, `C1355`, `C5315`, `C6288`, `C7552`, `dalu`, `i10`, `k2` and `mainpla`. Those AIGs have diverse sizes (from hunreds to hundreds of thousands of nodes) and encode diverse Boolean functions. For each AIG, we run PPO with different policies (no GCN, a small, a medium, a large and a very large GCN). For each policy and each AIG, the PPO is tuned and run on multiple seeds. We periodically save and evaluate the greedy PPO policy: we use the policy to minimize an AIG and we report the normalized AND counts after applying $H = 20$ `ABC` primitives (cf. section 4). All hyperparameters and implementation details are given in appendix A.1.

Paying the GCN memory overhead does not improve AIG minimization On figure 2, we observe that in average a tuned PPO can train a policy to minimize an AIG, independently of the policy architecture. Figure 8 in Appendix D breaks the same runs down by benchmark and this observation holds. However, we also observe that for all AIGs benchmarked, adding a GCN to the policy does not significantly improves performance (the improvement is within one seed variance). Most importantly, we see on the same figure that this marginal improvments costs orders of magnitude more memory compared to the policy reading only a features vector (cf. section 4). We repeated this experiment on a the set of 100 AIGs to minimize taken from the 2026 IWLS programming contest[2].

[2]

The above conclusion also holds for those AIGs as seen from Appendix B: paying the GCN cost does not significantly improve performances.

5.2 Value prediction

The previous section compares encoders inside one algorithm, so a null result there could be a property of that algorithm rather than of the representations. We therefore ask a question that does not involve a training algorithm at all: how well can the optimal value $V^\star$ of a state be predicted from what a given class of models is able to see?

5.2.1 Building a dataset

Computing $V^\star$ exactly is out of reach: the tree of flows over the five primitives of Section 4 has 5^H leaves, and every edge of it costs one `ABC` call on the full circuit. We therefore build, for each benchmark, a dataset of states paired with a Monte-Carlo estimate of their value, obtained by sampling both the states and the continuations from them.

States. A state is the AIG obtained by applying a uniformly random flow to the benchmark $\mathcal{G}_0$: we draw a length $L \sim \mathcal{U}\{2, \dots, 10\}$, then L primitives independently and uniformly from the five-element action set, and run them in order. We sample $1{,}000$ such states per benchmark. Each one is written to disk as an `.aig` file and stored together with the statistics $x_{\mathcal{G}}$ of Section 4 recorded at that point of the flow, so that every model class of Sections 5.2.2 and 5.2.3 is evaluated on exactly the same states and the same targets—the graph models read the `.aig` file, the MLP reads $x_{\mathcal{G}}$.

Targets. From each stored state s we run $M = 100$ independent rollouts of 8 further uniformly random primitives, reload the state between rollouts, and record the AND count $n^{(j)}(s)$ reached at the end of rollout j. The target is the best of them,$\widehat{V}(s) = \min_{j \le M} n^{(j)}(s)$, that is, the smallest AND count the sampler managed to reach within 8 actions of s. This is a best-of-M estimate: it is an upper bound on $\min$ over the 5^8 flows of length eight, and it approaches it from above as M grows. Producing one dataset therefore costs $1{,}000 \times (L + M \times 8) \approx 8 \times 10^5$ `ABC` primitive calls per benchmark and per seed, which is why M is lowered to 10 on `C6288`, by far the most expensive circuit of the suite to rewrite.

What the target measures. $\widehat{V}$ is expressed in AND nodes rather than in returns, so it is ordered the other way round from the value $V^\star$ of Section 3.2—smaller is better—and it truncates the horizon at eight steps instead of the $H = 20$ of the reinforcement learning experiments. Neither affects the comparison between model classes. The map $n \mapsto 1 - n/n_0$ from AND count to the reward of Section 4 is affine and order-reversing, all the errors we report are ratios to the variance of the target and are therefore free of its units, and the rank correlations we report are unchanged up to sign. What the truncation does mean is that our targets approximate the value of an eight-step-to-go problem under a best-of-M estimate, not the exact $V^\star$ of the full episode, and the bounds of Section 5.2.2 are lower bounds on the error of predicting *that* quantity.

Protocol. The procedure is repeated with ten seeds (0 to 9) per benchmark, each seed drawing its own $1{,}000$ states and its own rollouts, and each resulting dataset is split at random into training, validation and test sets; the figures of this section report over those ten repetitions. The benchmarks are the same ten MLCAD circuits as in Section 5.1. Two of them are degenerate for this purpose: the sampler reaches only six distinct values of $\widehat{V}$ on `C1355` and only two on `C6288`. We therefore exclude `C6288` and report over the remaining nine benchmarks, flagging `C1355` wherever it appears.

5.2.2 Theoretical lower bounds on the prediction error

A model that cannot distinguish two states must assign them the same prediction. For a class of models, this partitions the state space, and the best achievable squared error is attained by the predictor that outputs, for each part, the mean target over that part. That error is a lower bound: no model in the class can beat it, regardless of its size, its training procedure or its optimization. This is the protocol of `Graphtester` [1], which measures the theoretical boundary of graph neural networks on a given dataset rather than the performance of one trained instance; we reimplement it so that it applies to our four state representations and to the target of Section 5.2.1.

The classes we bound. We compute the bound for four classes, ordered by what they can see. A *size* model sees the number of nodes $|V_{\mathcal{G}}|$ alone—this is what a 0-layer message passing network reduces to, since with no rounds of message passing the readout can only count nodes. A *size and depth* model sees the pair $(|V_{\mathcal{G}}|, d_{\mathcal{G}})$, where $d_{\mathcal{G}}$ is the logic depth reported by `ABC`. An $x_{\mathcal{G}}$ model sees the engineered statistics of Section 4 in full, the action histogram included, which is exactly what the MLP baseline reads. A *message passing* model sees the 1-WL coloring of the AIG, which upper bounds the separating power of every architecture of Section 3.3 by the argument given there. Comparing the third and the fourth is the question of this section: what a learned encoder could express, against what the statistics already express. The two are incomparable rather than nested, and this matters for reading the result below. Only the current size and depth entries of $x_{\mathcal{G}}$ are functions of the current AIG; the previous step's size and depth, the normalized time step and the action histogram are episode history that no encoder of the current graph can recover. The $x_{\mathcal{G}}$ bound may therefore fall below the 1-WL bound without contradicting it, and a policy that reads both—which is what Algorithm 1 does—is bounded by neither alone.

Computing the partitions. For the first two classes the partition is by exact equality of the descriptors. For $x_{\mathcal{G}}$, the full feature vector is snapped to a grid of spacing 10^{-8} and states are grouped by equality of the snapped vector, so the model we bound and the MLP of Section 4 see the same thing. For message passing, we group states by their 1-WL graph hash, computed with `networkx`'s [13] `weisfeiler_lehman_graph_hash` at every number of iterations $k = 1, \ldots, 50$, with each node labeled by its type.[3] We bound four views of the AIG, which is what the four message passing curves of Figure 3 report: the undirected graph $\mathcal{G}$, the directed graph $\mathcal{G}^{\rightarrow}$ in which refinement follows the fanin relation, and the two variants $\mathcal{G}^{e}, \mathcal{G}^{\rightarrow e}$ that additionally label each edge with its complement bit, so that inversion is visible to the refinement rather than only through node types. Errors are divided by $\max(1, \mathrm{Var}\,\widehat{V})$; in AND-node units the variance is orders of magnitude above one on every benchmark, so the clamp never binds and the reported quantity is the plain normalized error.

Metrics. Besides the squared error we report how well each class can *order* states, since a critic that ranks successors correctly is useful even when its absolute errors are large. We measure the rank association between $\widehat{V}$ and the group-mean predictor of the class with Spearman's ρ, Kendall's τ, and the weighted τ, which puts more weight on the top of the ranking—the states an agent would actually select. Rank correlations are computed at $k = 50$ refinement iterations.

A control for partition granularity. The bound is computed in sample: the group means are fitted on the same $1{,}000$ states the error is measured on. A partition fine enough to isolate every state therefore drives it to zero regardless of whether the representation carries any signal about $\widehat{V}$. We control for this by recomputing every bound with the targets randomly permuted across states—25 permutations per dataset, 8 on `mainpla` and `C6288`—which leaves the partition intact and destroys the association. The gap between a curve and its permuted counterpart, not the height of the curve, is what indicates that a representation carries information about the value; the same control is applied to the rank correlations, where the null is the correlation between $\widehat{V}$ and a random permutation of itself. Every bound we report sits one to two orders of magnitude below its shuffled-label counterpart—between 11 and 474 times below it, depending on the benchmark—so the partitions are not merely fine enough to memorize the targets. The two partitions we compare are also of nearly equal granularity, at 865 parts for $x_{\mathcal{G}}$ and 860 for 1-WL out of $1{,}000$ states on average, so neither class is given more degrees of freedom than the other.

No message passing network can predict $\widehat{V}$ as well as the statistics the MLP already sees (Figure 3). A k-layer MPNN separates graphs at most as finely as k iterations of 1-WL, so grouping states by their 1-WL color and predicting each group's mean $\widehat{V}$ gives an error no MPNN can beat; the same construction bounds a 0-layer network, a $(\mathrm{size}, \mathrm{depth})$ model, and a model seeing the MLP's features $x_{\mathcal{G}}$. Message passing is worth a great deal over global descriptors: the bound falls from 0.02–0.64 of the target variance for node count alone, to 1.1×10^{-3}–0.24 once depth is added, and

[3] The hash is a 16-byte `blake2b` digest. A collision would merge two groups that 1-WL separates and can only raise the reported value, so the bound would become conservative rather than optimistic; at $1{,}000$ graphs per dataset the probability of one is negligible.

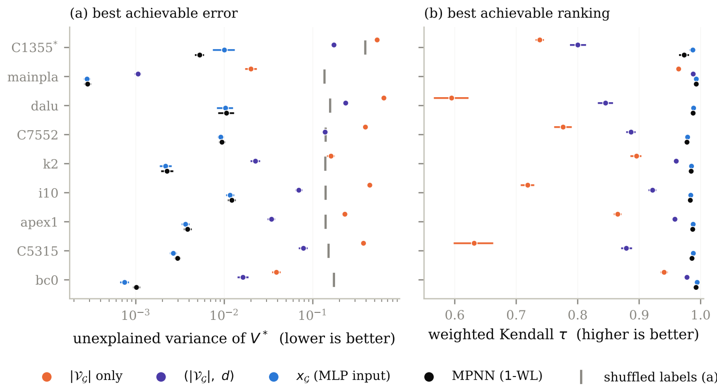

Figure 3: Best error (a) and best ranking (b) achievable by each model class on $\widehat{V}$, over nine benchmarks and ten dataset seeds. Each class is replaced by the optimal predictor for the information it can distinguish, so the value shown cannot be beaten by any model in that class. *`C1355` has only six distinct targets.

to 3×10^{-4}–1.2×10^{-2} for 1-WL. It is worth nothing over x_G. On eight of the nine benchmarks the x_G bound is the *lower* of the two, at 0.73 to 0.99 times the MPNN bound; only `C1355` goes the other way, where message passing is better by $1.93\times$. The ordering is stable within a dataset: paired by seed, x_G is lower on all ten seeds of six benchmarks and on seven and eight of ten for `dalu` and `C7552`. For ranking the two classes are indistinguishable — weighted Kendall $\tau \geq 0.97$ for both on every benchmark, with x_G ahead by at most 0.014 — while size and depth alone reach only 0.60–0.99. This is possible because x_G is not a coarsening of the graph: it carries the episode history described above, which no encoder of the current AIG can reconstruct. Depth is irrelevant — the bound moves by at most 1.1×10^{-3} between $k = 1$ and $k = 50$, and edge direction and inverter bits change it by less than 10^{-6} (Appendix C). `C6288` is excluded: its target takes two distinct values.

Limitations of the bounds. Four restrictions should be read with the numbers above. First, they hold over the state distribution of Section 5.2.1—AIGs reached by uniformly random flows of length two to ten—and not over the states a trained policy visits, which are fewer and more correlated; a representation could be uninformative on the former and useful on the latter. Second, each dataset descends from a single benchmark, so what is bounded is the ability to tell apart states *of one circuit*, whereas the argument for learned encoders in Section 4 is transfer *across* circuits; our experiment does not test that claim, and a cross-circuit dataset could behave differently. Third, $\widehat{V}$ is a Monte-Carlo estimate, so part of its variance is sampling noise that no representation can predict. That noise raises every bound by roughly the same amount and therefore compresses the ratios between classes towards one, which works in favor of the negative conclusion we draw; the 1-WL and x_G bounds being close is evidence that message passing adds little, but not proof that the noise floor is not what they are both close to. Fourth, the 1-WL argument covers message passing networks whose input is the AIG with node-type features, which is the setting of Section 4 and of Zhu et al. [51]. It does not cover higher-order architectures, models given node identifiers or positional encodings, nor encoders whose node features are not a function of the graph alone—the simulation-derived features used by some AIG-specific models are an example, and for those the bound of Figure 3 is not binding.

5.2.3 Empirical performances of AIG-specific models on value prediction

The bounds of Section 5.2.2 say what a representation *could* express. This section asks what models actually trained on the same datasets achieve, which is the quantity a critic in Algorithm 1 would reach.

Models. We train eight regressors on the datasets of Section 5.2.1. Four are generic message passing networks—GCN [18], GIN [47], GAT [43] and GraphSAGE [14]—taken from `PyTorch Geometric` [9]. Three are AIG-specific: DeepGate [19], PolarGate [22] and FuncGNN [49], each run from its authors' implementation. The eighth is the MLP of Section 4, which reads x_G and no

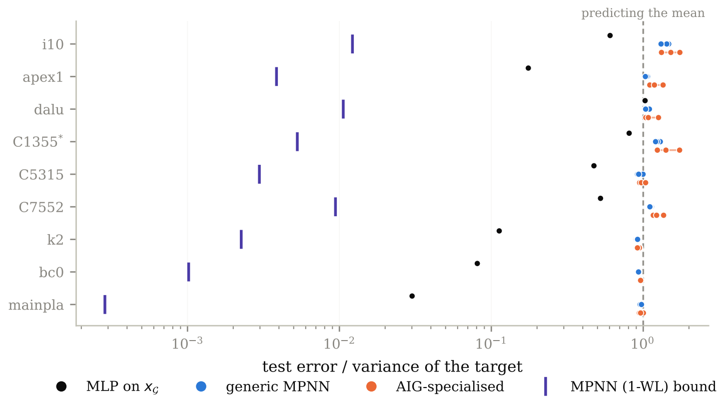

Figure 4: Test error of eight trained models, normalized by the variance of the target so that 1.0 is the error of predicting the mean. Violet ticks: the 1-WL bound of Figure 3.

graph at all, and is the baseline the graph models have to beat. All eight share the same head so that only the encoder differs: node embeddings are mean-pooled into one vector per AIG, which a two-layer ReLU network maps to a scalar. GCN, GIN and GraphSAGE consume the six-way one-hot node type of Section 4; GAT, PolarGate and FuncGNN consume the three-way type (input, AND, inverter) of the DeepGate reader, with the inverter bit exposed as a signed edge feature, so that the models that were designed to use complementation receive it. DeepGate is the one exception to end-to-end training: we load the pretrained encoder, freeze it, and train only the head on its mean-pooled functional embeddings, which is how it is meant to be used as a general-purpose circuit encoder.

Training and selection. Targets are $\widehat{V}$ divided by the AND count of the benchmark's initial AIG, so they lie in $(0, 1]$ and are comparable across circuits. Each dataset of $1{,}000$ states is split $80/10/10$ into training, validation and test sets by a permutation seeded by the run seed. Models are trained for $1{,}000$ epochs with Adam [17] on the mean squared error. Each architecture is given its own grid of 36 configurations, and 12 for DeepGate, whose frozen encoder leaves only the head to tune. The grid is run at seed 0, the configuration with the lowest final validation error is selected, and that configuration alone is then rerun on the ten seeds we report; the seed selects the dataset, the split and the initialization together, so the ten repetitions are independent in all three. Appendix A.2 gives the grids. We report test error normalized by the variance of the test targets, so that 1.0 is the error of predicting the mean.

Caveats. Two aspects of the protocol should be read with the numbers below. First, the baseline is the same throughout the paper: the MLP reads x_G, action histogram included, both here and in the bound of Section 5.2.2, and every model is evaluated on the same states and the same targets, so the graph models are measured against one fixed reference rather than against a moving one. Second, the grid is searched at seed 0 only, and the selected configuration is then rerun on ten seeds; a configuration that happens to suit seed 0 could be favored, and this concerns the models trained end to end rather than DeepGate, whose pretrained encoder is frozen and whose grid therefore only tunes a two-layer head. More generally, one grid, one head architecture and $1{,}000$ epochs is less tuning than these encoders received in the papers that introduced them, so we read the result below as evidence that they do not fit this target out of the box, not as an upper bound on what they could reach with more effort.

Trained graph models, including AIG-specific ones, do not beat predicting the mean (Figure 4). All seven graph models land between 0.90 and 1.74 times the target variance — at or above the constant predictor — while the MLP reaches 0.47 at the median. Their training error is also ≈ 1, so this is a failure to fit rather than to generalize, and it leaves them two to three orders of magnitude above the bound of Figure 3 that their own architecture class admits. The per-dataset validation curves of Figure 9 in Appendix D show the graph models settling at the level of the constant predictor early in training and staying there.

6 Future work

Our results are restricted to the setting used by past work: a policy gradient algorithm, five `ABC` primitives as actions, and the fixed horizon of Section 4. Two of those choices—the algorithm and the action space—bear directly on how much a learned representation of the circuit could contribute, and relaxing them is where we would look next.

Other reinforcement learning algorithms. AIG editing is deterministic and its exploration problem is hard, a combination for which value-based algorithms [45, 27] are usually competitive, yet the existing work on AIG reduction surveyed in Section 2 is entirely policy gradient-based. That distinction matters here rather than only for sample efficiency: a value-based agent acts by comparing the predicted values of successor states, so its behavior rests entirely on the quantity Section 5.2 measures, whereas in an actor-critic method the value estimate only shapes the advantage. If the representation is the bottleneck anywhere, it should be there, and our experiments do not answer whether a graph encoder helps under such an algorithm.

The full `ABC` action space. Five primitives give the policy little to decide, and the states it can reach are the images of a handful of short sequences, which may be why the statistics of Section 4 suffice to tell them apart. `ABC` exposes many more primitives, and our environment already implements that larger action space (Section 4) even though the experiments above do not use it. With more primitives, reachable states would differ from one another in more ways, and a representation that sees the circuit rather than its summary would have correspondingly more to distinguish. Rerunning both the ablation of Section 5.1 and the bounds of Section 5.2.2 over that action space would say whether our negative result is a property of AIG reduction itself or of the small action space it is usually given.

Further out. Two directions follow from the material above. A finer-grained action space—edits of individual nodes or cones rather than the whole-graph primitives of Figure 1—would produce states that differ locally, and is the setting in which a structural representation would have the most room to help, at the price of having to enforce functional equivalence explicitly rather than inheriting it from the primitives. Separately, Stoll et al. [39] report that DAG generative models fail at AIG reduction without establishing why; the bounds we compute measure what a representation can distinguish, and applying them to the generative setting would test whether the same limitation is at play.

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A Hyper-parameters

A.1 Graph encoders and reinforcement learning

The environment. The MDP of Section 4 instantiates the MDP of Section 3.2 with the five `ABC` primitives as actions, where `-z` enables zero-cost replacements. Episodes start from $\mathcal{G}_0$ and last exactly $H = 20$ actions with no early stopping. Because every primitive preserves functional equivalence, the problem of Section 3.1 is never violated, only under-solved. The reward is a level rather than a difference, so the return is maximized by an agent that keeps the AIG small throughout the episode and not merely at the end. Our environment also implements a seven-action variant adding `resub` and `resub -z`, and the full `ABC` action space, neither of which is used in our experiments.

The observation. Writing n_t and ℓ_t for the number of AND nodes and of levels after t actions, the vector part of the observation is

$$x_{\mathcal{G}} = \Big[\underbrace{\tfrac{1}{q}\textstyle\sum_{j=1}^{q} \mathbf{1}[a_{t-j} = a],}_{a \in A}\ \frac{n_t}{n_0},\ \frac{\ell_t}{\ell_0},\ \frac{n_{t-1}}{n_0},\ \frac{\ell_{t-1}}{\ell_0},\ \frac{t}{H}\Big].$$

The first $|A| = 5$ entries are a normalized histogram of the last q actions, with $q = 3$ like in Zhu et al. [51]; the next four are the AND and level counts of the current and of the previous AIG, each divided by its value in $\mathcal{G}_0$ so that the vector is scale-free across benchmarks of very different sizes; the last is the normalized time step, which makes the finite-horizon problem Markov in the observation. It is computed in a single pass over the graph and adds no parameters of its own. The graph part of the observation is the AIG itself, as in Zhu et al. [51]: nodes carry a one-hot encoding of their type among the six types `abc_py` exposes, a directed edge runs from each fanin to the node it feeds, and edges carry no label.

The encoders. Table 1 lists the four graph encoders of Section 4: three at depth three with widths from 12 to 128, and one at depth five, so that depth and width are not confounded. Each runs the message passing rounds of Section 3.3 over the AIG and pools the node embeddings into a graph-level vector concatenated with $x_{\mathcal{G}}$ before the policy and value heads. The baseline uses no encoder at all and reads $x_{\mathcal{G}}$ alone through a multi-layer perceptron.

Table 1: The four graph encoders. Depth is the number of message passing rounds, width the hidden dimension, and output the dimension of the pooled vector concatenated with $x_{\mathcal{G}}$.

encoder	depth	width	output
`small`	3	12	4
`medium`	3	64	32
`large`	3	128	64
`v. large`	5	128	64

Training. Policies are trained with the PPO implementation of `stable-baselines3` [36] with $\gamma = 1$, the horizon being finite and fixed, and the encoder is trained end to end with the policy and value heads rather than pre-trained or frozen. Eight environments run in parallel and each contributes 20 steps per update, so an update is computed from 160 transitions and a single episode spans five updates; 8,000 environment steps therefore amount to $N = 50$ updates. After every update we evaluate the greedy policy for one episode, which is the quantity the learning curves report. The policy and value heads are each two hidden layers of 256 units and share the encoder of line 7 of Algorithm 1. Algorithm 1 states the resulting procedure, which we call GRAPHPPO: it is ordinary PPO with the encoder made explicit, the encoding of the current AIG being the only place where the five configurations we compare differ.

The grid of Section 5.1 crosses three learning rates (10^{-4}, 10^{-5}, 10^{-6}), three entropy coefficients (0, 0.01, 0.1) and five seeds, which with five encoders and ten benchmarks gives the 2,250 runs reported there. Twenty-six of those runs (eighteen `small`, eight `v. large`) stopped before the fiftieth update; we drop them rather than pad them, and requiring all five encoders to have completed a given (benchmark, learning rate, entropy, seed) cell leaves 424 of the 450 cells.

Algorithm 1 GraphPPO. The encoder f_θ is the only component that varies across the runs we compare; everything else is held fixed.

Require: AIG $\mathcal{G}_0$ to reduce with n_0 AND nodes, encoder f_θ, policy head π_θ, value head V_θ, action set A of five `ABC` primitives, fixed horizon $H = 20$, iterations N, epochs K, clipping ϵ, entropy weight β, value weight c, step size η

$n^\star \leftarrow n_0$
for $i = 1, \dots, N$ **do**
  $\mathcal{D} \leftarrow \emptyset$
  for each parallel environment **do**
    $\mathcal{G} \leftarrow \mathcal{G}_0$
    for $t = 0, \dots, H-1$ **do**
      $s_t \leftarrow \big(f_\theta(\mathcal{G}),\ x_{\mathcal{G}}\big)$ ▷ f_θ is a GCN, or is absent for the baseline
      $a_t \sim \pi_\theta(\cdot \mid s_t), \quad a_t \in A$
      $\mathcal{G} \leftarrow \textsc{Abc}(\mathcal{G}, a_t)$ ▷ deterministic, preserves functional equivalence
      $r_t \leftarrow 1 - |V^{AND}(\mathcal{G})| \,/\, n_0$ ▷ relative size, issued at every step
      $\mathcal{D} \leftarrow \mathcal{D} \cup \{(s_t, a_t, r_t, \log \pi_\theta(a_t \mid s_t), V_\theta(s_t))\}$
      $n^\star \leftarrow \min\big(n^\star,\ |V^{AND}(\mathcal{G})|\big)$
    end for
  end for
  compute returns $\hat{R}_t$ and advantages $\hat{A}_t$ from $\mathcal{D}$
  $\theta_{\text{old}} \leftarrow \theta$
  for K epochs over minibatches of $\mathcal{D}$ **do**
    $\rho_t(\theta) \leftarrow \pi_\theta(a_t \mid s_t) \,/\, \pi_{\theta_{\text{old}}}(a_t \mid s_t)$
    $L(\theta) \leftarrow \widehat{\mathbb{E}}_t\big[\min\big(\rho_t \hat{A}_t,\ \text{clip}(\rho_t, 1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon)\hat{A}_t\big) - c\big(V_\theta(s_t) - \hat{R}_t\big)^2 + \beta\,\mathcal{H}\big[\pi_\theta(\cdot \mid s_t)\big]\big]$
    $\theta \leftarrow \theta + \eta\,\nabla_\theta L(\theta)$ ▷ gradients flow through f_θ
  end for
end for
return $n^\star$, the smallest AND count visited

A.2 Value prediction

The models of Section 5.2.3 are trained in mini-batches of 16 unless the batch size is itself searched over. Each architecture's grid of 36 configurations crosses three learning rates (10^{-3}, 5×10^{-4}, 10^{-4}) with a width and a depth, or with the number of attention heads for GAT and the polarity weight for PolarGate. DeepGate is the exception, with 12 configurations: its pretrained encoder is frozen, so only the two-layer head is tuned.

B The ex200–ex299 suite

We repeat the comparison of Section 5.1 on ex200–ex299, a suite spanning 106 to 46,977 input AND gates and therefore both larger and more varied than the ten MLCAD circuits. Each encoder ran at its own baseline hyper-parameters here instead of over the matched grid. The three GCNs reduce the final AND count by 0.33–0.71% against a reseed standard deviation of 0.54% (Figure 5), and the difference is flat across two and a half orders of magnitude of circuit size (Figure 6), so the conclusion of Section 5.1 appears to hold here as well. The MLP runs were executed on CPU and did not finish on the largest circuits, which is why 20 of the 100 benchmarks are excluded; the comparison is therefore made on the smaller eighty, and we cannot rule out that the largest circuits behave differently.

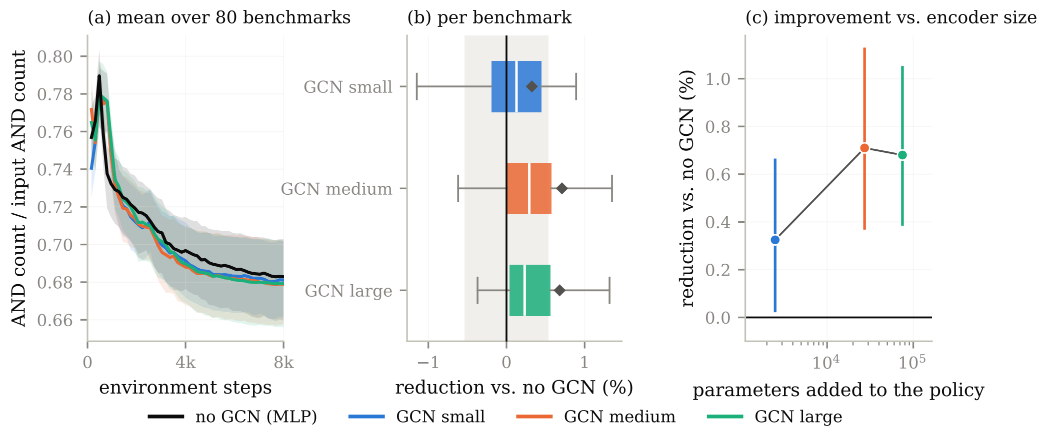

Figure 5: The comparison of Figure 2 on ex200–ex299, where each encoder ran at its own baseline hyper-parameters instead of the matched grid. Restricted to the 390 of 500 (benchmark, seed) cells all four encoders completed, covering 80 benchmarks.

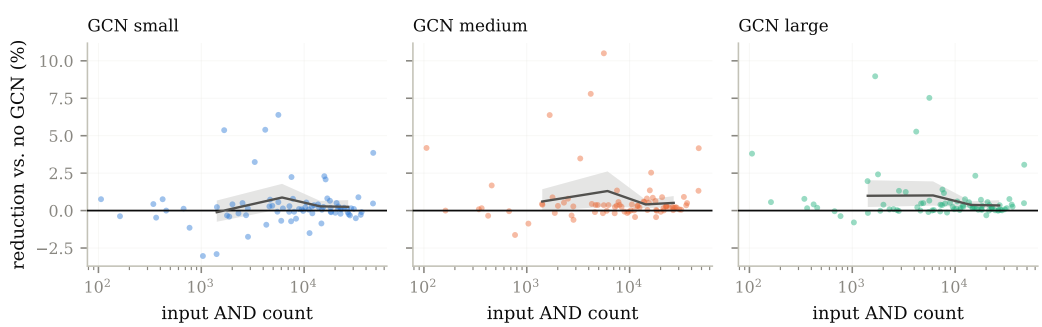

Figure 6: Reduction against the MLP as a function of input circuit size on ex200–ex299. Line: mean over size quartiles.

C The message passing bound against depth

Figure 7 plots the message passing bound of Section 5.2.2 against the number of refinement iterations k, for the four views of the AIG bounded there. The bound moves by at most 1.1×10^{-3} between $k = 1$ and $k = 50$, and labeling edges with direction or with the complement bit changes it by less than 10^{-6}, so neither deeper refinement nor a richer view of the graph brings a message passing network closer to $\widehat{V}$.

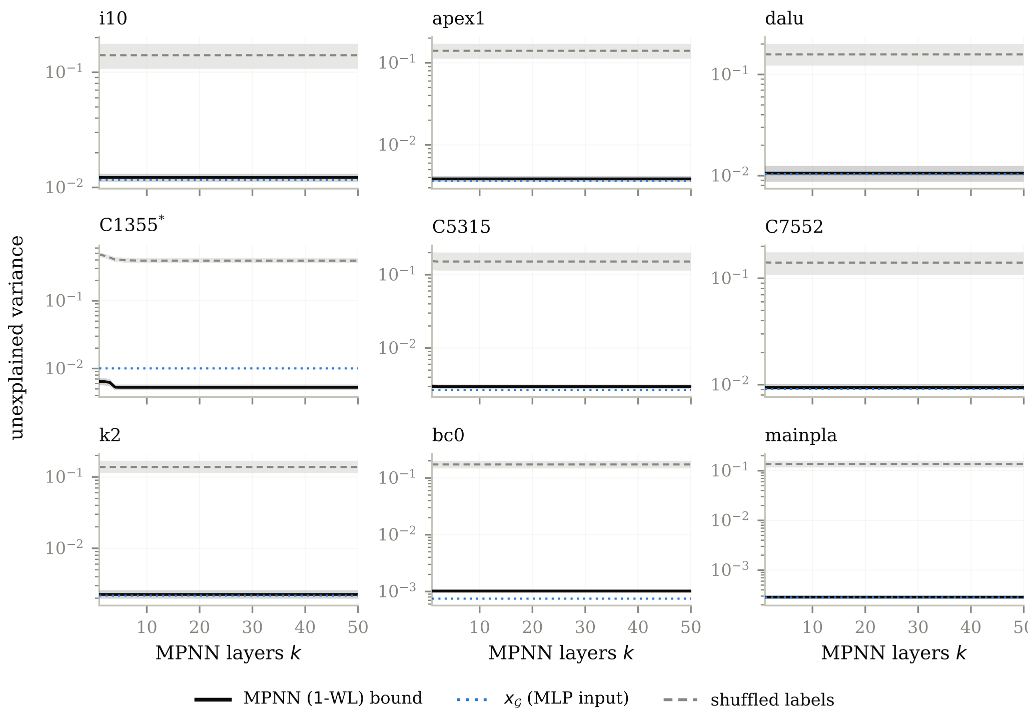

Figure 7: The MPNN bound as a function of depth k.

D Per-dataset curves

Figure 8 resolves the aggregate of Figure 2(a) into one learning curve per benchmark, and Figure 9 shows validation error over training for the value prediction models of Figure 4.

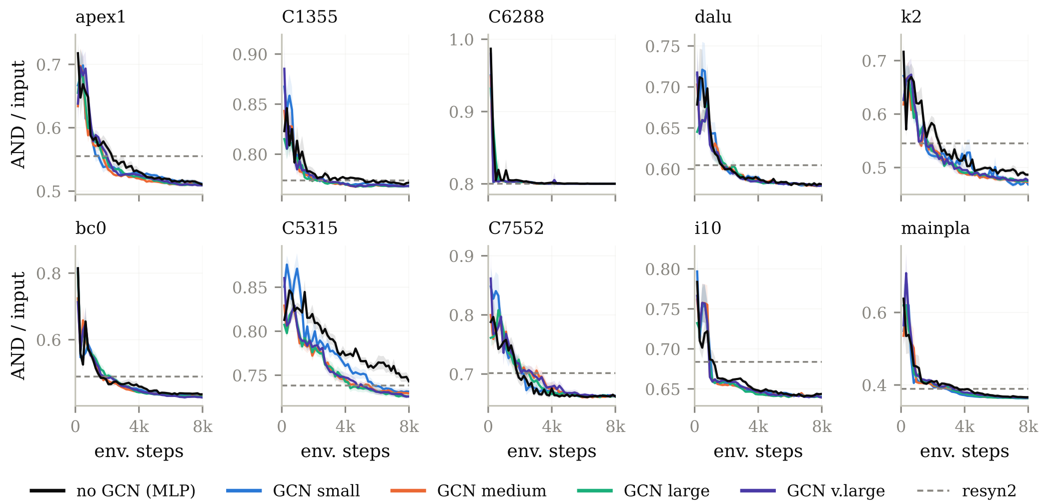

Figure 8: Per-benchmark learning curves for the runs aggregated in Figure 2(a). Dashed line: `resyn2`.

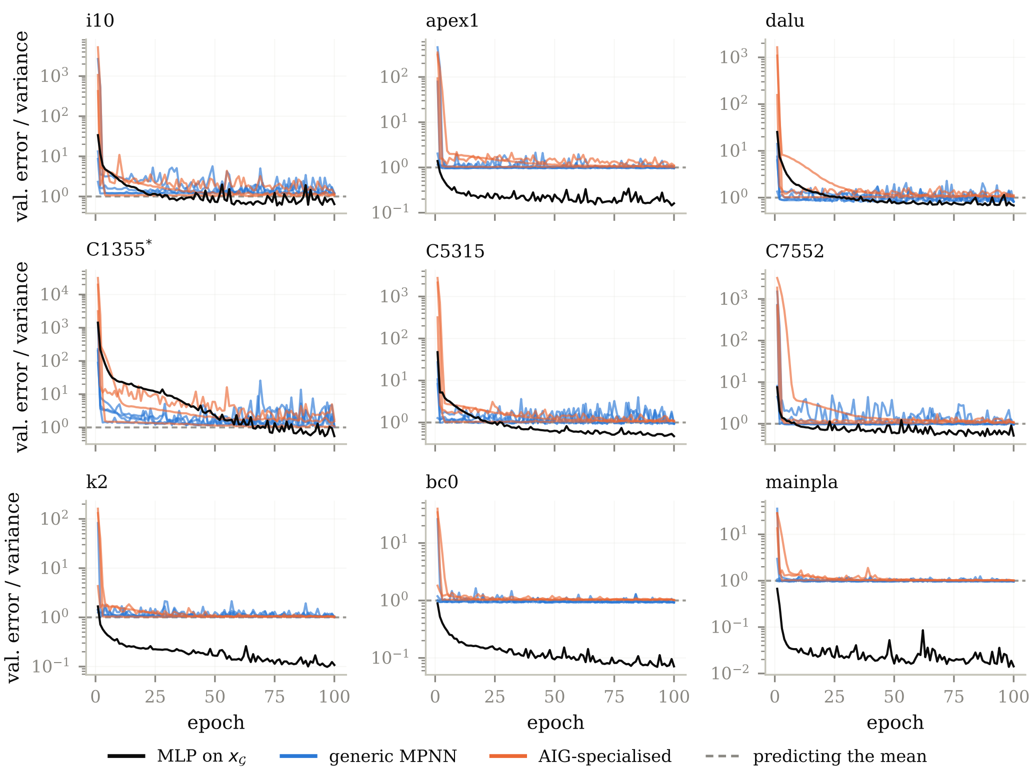

Figure 9: Validation error over training for the configurations of Figure 4, one panel per benchmark.

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